conquests, Germany, along with its capital, Berlin, was divided into four zones of allied influence—governed by the United States, France, Great Britain, and the Soviet Union (USSR), respectively—designed to both punish the country and guard its peaceful reconstruction. As tensions increased between the Western NATO allies and the Warsaw Pact countries of the Eastern bloc nations, with the United States and the USSR as its central players, the Western powers consolidated their occupied sectors as the western Federal Republic of Germany, while the Russians shaped the eastern German Democratic Republic (GDR) within the Soviet bloc. The country split into two hostile, internecine, neighboring nations. The division of the formerly unified city of Berlin, geographically situated 110 miles from the West German border and otherwise surrounded by East Germany, rendered West Berlin an island and outpost of the West. The terms of American occupation and involvement with West Germany's governance and East Germany's status as an adversarial state demanded a complicated understanding of America's geopolitical stance during this period. From the Berlin airlift of 1948–49, when the U.S. Air Force and allies delivered rations and supplies to West Berlin for a year in response to a Soviet blockade of all ground routes to the city, to the Berlin Crisis of 1958–61, when tempers flared between the superpowers around control and access to the city, American politicians and citizens demonstrated a deep investment in the ongoing fate of Berlin. As Andreas Daum notes, a month before the Berlin border was closed, 85 percent of U.S. citizens wanted troops to stay in West Berlin; a month after the border wall materialized, 70 percent would have supported going to war to secure access to the city.[10]

Both sides of Cold War Berlin were pivotal venues for assessing the U.S. attempt to claim status as guarantor of global democracy and freedom against the Soviet Union. Daum suggests that the shift from the popular notion of "Hitler's Berlin" to "America's Berlin"—the "political and symbolic place" both in and out of the United States "that incorporated Berlin into the history of the United States and linked the often dramatic events in the German capital … to America's own cultural memory"—occurred in the years after 1961, as the divided city was experiencing both a remilitarization and cultural reinvention.[11] The Berlin Wall's presence marked no simple way to affirm or disprove this transition to "America's Berlin." Instead the many cultural expressions representing the Wall's construction and maintenance demonstrated the flurry of ideological,